



Beneath a Crimson Banner

A Total War: Three Kingdoms Modlist for v1.7.2

Three Waves · Three Campaigns · One Destiny

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Wave 0 — The Warlord’s First Steps

Roleplaying Background

The Han dynasty crumbles. Yellow Turban rebels burn the countryside, and warlords across the land sharpen their blades. You are not yet among them — you are a minor official, a displaced captain, or a wandering scholar. The world is vast and dangerous. Every decision matters.

Your goal: survive. Learn the land. Build a following.

Game Setup

| Setting | Choice | |---|---| | Difficulty | Normal | | Campaign | Mandate of Heaven / Rise of the Warlords (any) | | Faction | Any recommended starter faction (e.g., Cao Cao, Sun Jian, Liu Bei) | | Turn Timer | Unlimited | | Battle Time Limit | 60 min |

Mods in This Wave

This wave uses only UI improvements and quality-of-life mods. No gameplay overhauls. This is the vanilla experience — polished.

How to Use This Guide

Read 02-how-to-play.md for a complete beginner’s guide to the game’s systems. The mod list above is installed via TW Mod Manager — see setup-installation-guide.md for instructions.

Mod List

Example UI Improvement Mod

by ExampleAuthor

v1.0.0

UI

Improves the campaign map UI with better tooltips and information panels.

Load after any total conversion mods.

Example QoL Fixes

by AnotherAuthor

v2.3.1

QOL

Fixes various quality-of-life issues including diplomatic feedback and recruitment sorting.

⚠️ Conflict:

Example UI Improvement Mod → Load after Example UI Improvement Mod

A Complete Guide to Total War: Three Kingdoms

The Campaign Map

Settlements & Resources

- **Commanderies** are provinces containing multiple settlements
- **Counties** are individual towns; assign governors for bonuses
- **Resources** (copper, iron, horses, etc.) provide faction-wide bonuses
- Build orders: prioritize food, then income, then public order

Characters & Court

- **Characters** are your generals, administrators, and family
- **Satisfaction** determines loyalty — low satisfaction leads to defection
- **Assignments** send characters on missions for bonuses
- **Court positions** grant satisfaction bonuses to holders
- **Marriage & adoption** expand your family tree

Government & Reforms

- **Reforms** are a tech tree unlocked over time
- **Government type** affects court position availability and satisfaction
- **Corruption** increases with empire size — counter with buildings and reforms

Diplomacy

- **Relations** affect treaty acceptance
- **Coalitions** are defensive alliances
- **Trade agreements** require a connected route
- **Marriage alliances** bind families together
- **Cooldowns** prevent repeated war declarations

Battles

Land Battles

- **Formations:** Shield wall, diamond, spear wall, etc.
- **Terrain:** High ground grants morale and missile damage bonuses
- **Weather:** Rain reduces missile accuracy, fire ammo
- **Morale:** Route units by flanking and general kills
- **Units:** Spear beats cavalry, cavalry beats ranged, ranged beats infantry

Siege Battles

- **Siege engines** break walls and gates
- **Ladders** allow assault on walls
- **Towers** fire on attackers automatically
- **Attrition** wears down a garrison over time

Espionage

- **Spies** can be embedded in enemy armies and courts
- **Reveal** enemy spy networks with your own administrators
- **Assassinations, sabotage, and incitement** are available actions

Economy

- **Food surplus** keeps armies fed and public order high

- **Income** from commerce, industry, and taxation
- **Trade ports** generate significant wealth
- **Reforms** unlock economic bonuses

Victory Conditions

- **Short campaign:** Own X territories, achieve Y prestige
- **Long campaign:** Control three of China's key commanderies
- **Kingdoms:** Become king, then emperor, then conquer all

Tips for New Players

1. Focus on food first — starvation destroys public order
2. Don't overextend — one army per front, two max
3. Use spies liberally — information wins wars
4. Keep heirs and generals satisfied with court positions
5. Build roads — trade income depends on connections
6. Save before major battles — learn from defeats
7. Don't trust Sun Jian's peace offers (historical accuracy)

Wave 1 — The Kingdom Endures

Roleplaying Background

Years have passed. Your warlord now commands a stable domain — a true kingdom with borders, allies, and enemies. The world is no longer about survival but about expansion. Trade routes stretch across your lands. Your generals are seasoned veterans. But new threats gather at every border.

Your goal: secure your kingdom's future through diplomacy, strategy, and well-placed force.

Game Setup

| Setting | Choice | |---|---| | Difficulty | Hard | | Campaign | Rise of the Warlords | | Faction | Any major regional power (e.g., Gongsun Zan, Yuan Shao, Liu Biao) | | Turn Timer | Unlimited | | Battle Time Limit | 60 min |

What's New

- **Graphics overhaul** — the world looks richer and more immersive
- **Content mods** — new units, buildings, and events
- **Audio pack** — thematic battle music
- **Mechanic mods** — deeper systems (may affect diplomacy, economy, or spies)

Strategy Shift

On Hard difficulty, the AI is more aggressive and makes smarter decisions. Read 02-strategy.md for advanced tactics.

Mod List

Example Graphics Overhaul by GraphicsAuthor

v2.0.0

GRAPHICS

High-resolution textures for units, buildings, and campaign map.

Requires high-end GPU.

Example Content Expansion by ContentAuthor

v1.5.0

CONTENT

Adds new unique units, buildings, and events for several factions.

Dependencies: Example Graphics Overhaul

 **Conflict:** Another Content Mod → Load this one first, then Another Content Mod

 Adds unique faction buildings with new recruitment options

Start a new campaign after enabling.

Example Audio Pack by AudioAuthor

v1.0.0

AUDIO

Replaces battle music with traditional Chinese instruments.

Compatible with all overhauls.

Advanced Strategy for Wave 1

Campaign Strategy on Hard

Early Game (First 20 Turns)

1. **Secure your home commandery** — build the food chain first (farm > market > workshop)
2. **One army, one purpose** — don't split forces early; focus on one enemy at a time
3. **Diplomacy is defense** — use non-aggression pacts to protect flanks
4. **Spies in every court** — embed early, reap intelligence later

Mid Game (Turns 20-60)

1. **Two-front planning** — by now you have two armies; they should push opposite directions
2. **Governor assignments** — assign characters to rich commanderies for bonuses
3. **Reform priorities** — unlock administrative reforms before military ones
4. **Coalitions** — join or form one to deter large aggressors

Late Game (Turns 60+)

1. **Kingmaking** — once you become king, expect the “kingdom” diplomatic penalty
2. **Economic consolidation** — ensure every territory generates profit
3. **Elite armies** — replace militia with elite units as income allows
4. **The final push** — three kingdoms remain; choose your moment

Battle Tactics for Hard

- **AI uses flanking** — always reserve cavalry for counter-flanking
- **Moral shocks** — focus fire on enemy general; loss of general = route cascade
- **Terrain denial** — capture high ground before engaging
- **Siege patience** — build siege engines rather than assaulting walls directly
- **Retreat is an option** — preserve armies, fight another day

Mod-Aware Strategy

- New units from content mods have unique strengths — read their descriptions
- Audio mods give cues for battlefield events (listen for unique instrument cues)
- If a mechanic mod changes public order or corruption, adjust building priorities accordingly

Wave 2 — Beneath a Crimson Banner

Roleplaying Background

The empire burns. You are no longer a warlord or a king — you are the last hope of a dying age. Your territories stretch across China, but every border is contested. Generals scheme for your throne. The people grow restless. Three kingdoms stand between you and ultimate dominion, and the world itself seems to conspire against you.

This is the final wave. There is no backup plan. No retreat. Only victory or annihilation.

Your goal: unite China under your banner — or watch it all burn.

Game Setup

| Setting | Choice | |---| | Difficulty | Legendary | | Campaign | Mandate of Heaven | | Faction | Any (recommend a faction you know well from Waves 0-1) | | Turn Timer | Unlimited | | Battle Time Limit | 60 min |

What's New

- **Full mechanical overhauls** — diplomacy, economy, and characters work differently
- **Endgame crisis events** — scripted challenges that test your empire
- **Maximum difficulty** — Legendary AI morale bonuses, no battle saves
- **Compatibility considerations** — some Wave 1 mods conflict; read carefully

The Challenge

Wave 2 is designed for players who have mastered Waves 0-1. If you haven't completed at least one campaign on Hard with Wave 1's modset, consider playing more before starting this wave.

Mod List

Example Total Overhaul by OverhaulAuthor

v3.0.0

MECHANICS

Complete overhaul of diplomacy, economy, and character systems.

Dependencies: Example Graphics Overhaul

⚠ **Conflict:** Example Content Expansion → Compatible only with patches from the mod page. Use the compatibility patch.

⚠ **Conflict:** Vanilla Diplomacy Fix → Incompatible — do not use together

⚙ Replaces the entire diplomacy system with a deeper offer-and-demand negotiation model. Adds population mechanics to economy. Introduces general loyalty factions.

Requires new campaign. Read the mod page carefully.

Example Endgame Challenge by ChallengeAuthor

v1.2.0

MECHANICS

Adds late-game crisis events, horde armies, and empire-shattering dilemmas.

Dependencies: Example Total Overhaul

⚙ Adds scripted endgame scenarios that trigger when certain conditions are met (e.g., territory count, prestige level)

Can be toggled on/off mid-campaign.

Expert Strategy for Wave 2

Campaign Strategy on Legendary

The First 50 Turns (Survival)

1. **Legendary AI cheats** — AI gets public order and morale bonuses. Plan for it.
2. **No battle saves** — every battle matters. Auto-resolve is more punishing.
3. **Aggressive expansion in the first 20 turns** — cripple your nearest rival before they grow
4. **Accept that you will lose settlements** — plan to retake, not to hold everything

Mod-Overhauled Systems

Diplomacy Overhaul

- The overhaul mod changes negotiation to a offer-demand system
- You must offer something of value for every request
- Trust is a resource — breaking treaties permanently damages relationships
- War declarations require casus belli or heavy diplomatic penalties

Economy Overhaul

- Population mechanics: larger cities drain food, generate wealth but require more public order
- Tax rate affects population growth — high taxes slow growth
- Trade route banditry: invest in road infrastructure to protect trade

Character Overhaul

- Generals have loyalty factions — they may rebel with their entire army
- Court politics matter: promote talented generals or risk defection
- Family tree management is critical — succession crises can end campaigns

Endgame Crisis Events

- **Horde armies** spawn from ungarded borders — keep reserve forces
- **Economic collapses** trigger when corruption reaches thresholds — reform down
- **Dilemmas** force choices between short-term gain and long-term stability
- **Rival kingdoms** coordinate against the player — divide and conquer

Battle Tactics for Legendary

- **Never autoresolve** against equal or greater forces — the calculator is ruthless
- **General sniping** is harder (AI protects generals better) — use cavalry traps
- **Morale management** is key — your units will break faster without your general nearby
- **Terrain is your only advantage** — always fight on favorable ground
- **Withdraw from unwinnable battles** — preserving armies is preserving campaign viability

Appendices

Mod Installation Guide

Setup & Installation Guide

Total War Mod Manager (TWMM)

TW Mod Manager is the recommended tool for managing Total War: Three Kingdoms mods.

Download & Install

1. Visit <https://www.nexusmods.com/site/mods/1238>

2. Download the latest version
3. Run the installer
4. On first launch, point TWMM to your Total War: Three Kingdoms installation folder (typically steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS)

Importing a Modlist

Each wave directory contains a `mods.yaml` file listing all mods and their sources.

1. Download each mod from its Nexus/Steam Workshop URL
2. Place `.pack` files in Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/
3. Open TWMM — it scans the data folder and lists all detected mods
4. Check the mods you want to enable for your current wave
5. Arrange load order (see below)

Load Order Rules

1. **Dependencies before dependents** — if Mod B needs Mod A, Mod A loads first
2. **UI mods load last** — UI changes should override everything else
3. **Audio mods load before content mods** — prevents conflicts
4. **Total overhauls load first** — they change the foundation everything else builds on

TWMM allows drag-and-drop reordering. Use the “Groups” feature to save load order profiles for each wave.

Verifying Compatibility

- TWMM checks for known conflicts and shows warnings
- Cross-reference with `conflicts.yaml` for tracked issues
- If TWMM shows a conflict, check the resolution field in the mod entry or `conflicts.yaml`

Per-Wave Profiles

1. In TWMM, create a “Wave 0” group with those mods enabled and all others disabled
2. When moving to Wave 1, disable all Wave 0 mods first, then enable Wave 1 mods
3. This prevents cross-wave conflicts

Manual Installation (Without TWMM)

1. Download mod `.pack` files
2. Place in steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/
3. Launch the game launcher
4. Go to “Mod Manager” tab
5. Enable mods in the correct order
6. Launch the game

“Note: The game’s built-in mod manager is less capable than TWMM. TWMM is strongly recommended.”